

H5 bird flu is a serious, highly contagious strain of bird flu that has been circulating globally. It mainly affects birds but can also infect other animals. Overseas, the H5 strain has caused severe disease and high death rates in poultry, wild birds and some mammals.

H5 bird flu has been detected in wildlife in Western Australia (WA), South Australia (SA), New South Wales (NSW), Queensland (QLD), Victoria (VIC) and Tasmania (TAS).

There have been no detections in poultry or the wider agricultural production system.

Detections in wildlife do not change Australia's status as free from high pathogenicity avian influenza in poultry in accordance with World Organisation for Animal Health international standards.

There is evidence of some local transmission of H5 bird flu among wild birds in southern parts of Australia and the first confirmed detection recorded in a marine mammal.

Based on overseas experience, it is not unexpected that additional cases may be detected in wildlife. It is not possible to eradicate H5 bird flu in wildlife.

A nationally agreed surveillance strategy for H5 bird flu in wildlife has been activated to support ongoing management and response.

The response focus continues to prioritise surveillance and early detection to reduce the impacts on wildlife, animal and human health, communities and agricultural industries.

Australia is well prepared to respond to H5 bird flu.

State and territory governments are leading response activities on the ground, including enhanced surveillance.

National coordination is being led by the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry. Nationally agreed arrangements have been activated to support ongoing management and response efforts focused on minimising impacts on wildlife, animal and human health, communities and agricultural industries.

Infected wildlife might look very sick or show no signs of disease at all. Birds can also die suddenly. For wild birds, signs may include difficulty standing, walking or flying, breathing problems, unusual head or neck posture, or sudden death.

If you're unsure and see sick or dead birds or other animals, do not touch them. Avoid contact. Record what you see. Report multiple sick or dead birds or other animals to the Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888 from anywhere in Australia.

Infected birds can spread the virus through body fluids, droppings and feathers. The virus can also spread through the air, or on contaminated clothing, shoes, animals, vehicles, equipment and water.

It is not possible to eradicate H5 bird flu in wildlife. The response focus continues to prioritise surveillance and early detection to reduce the impacts on wildlife, animal and human health, communities and agricultural industries.

Australia is home to many native animals that are unique to this continent. Because of this, the impacts of H5 bird flu here are difficult to predict.

Experience from overseas shows that H5 bird flu can have serious impacts on wild birds and some mammals. If the virus became established in Australian wildlife, some native species could experience significant illness and death. It will not be possible to prevent losses of wildlife in nature.

Find out more at [Understanding the risk to native species - DCCEEW](#)

If H5 bird flu establishes in Australia, our native species may face long term population setbacks. Some species might even be pushed towards extinction.

Efforts to protect native species include:

- improving biosecurity of captive threatened species
- supporting the development of preparedness and response plans for priority species and sites, which are guiding on-ground actions
- tackling other threats, so native species can better withstand and recover from the potential impacts of H5 bird flu.

Find out some simple ways you can help here: [How you can help - DCCEEW](#)

Australia is taking a national approach to the use of vaccinations to protect some of our most vulnerable native birds from H5 bird flu.

This builds on preparedness activities, including vaccine trials and pilot studies undertaken over the past 2 years.

Decisions on vaccination are made by state and territory governments using a nationally agreed framework that supports the targeted vaccination of priority native bird species that are captive or managed, including commencement of vaccination of little penguins in Victoria.

States and territories will consider a range of factors when identifying priority species for vaccination, including the conservation status and value of the species, the likelihood and potential consequences of H5 bird flu exposure, and whether vaccination can be delivered safely and effectively.

Vaccination can provide a level of protection against H5 bird flu infection for individual birds, but vaccination alone cannot be relied upon to prevent infection with H5 bird flu in priority native bird populations.

Biosecurity measures, including limiting direct and indirect contact between wild birds and threatened, captive populations, remain essential, alongside efforts activities to address other threats to Australian wildlife.

No. There have been no detections of H5 bird flu in poultry or the wider agriculture industry in Australia. Governments are working closely with the poultry industry to strengthen biosecurity and prevent outbreaks.

Bird owners can help protect their birds by preventing contact with wild birds and implementing good biosecurity practices including keeping equipment and enclosures clean and preventing contact between your birds and wild birds.

Keep watch for signs of bird flu and protect your birds by:

- keeping equipment and enclosures clean
- preventing contact between your birds and wild birds
- keeping food and water clean
- practicing good hygiene
- limiting visitor access
- quarantining new birds.

Find out more: [Poultry and livestock farmers and bird flu - DAFF](#)

H5 bird flu can spread directly to poultry from wild birds. It can also spread through:

- contaminated clothing, footwear, equipment or vehicles
- between birds
- contaminated poultry products, feed, equipment or other items.

The virus can also survive for long periods in droppings, respiratory secretions, water, feathers, eggs and meat.

Strong on-farm biosecurity and personal hygiene are the best methods of protecting birds and workers from disease.

Find out more: [Poultry and livestock farmers and bird flu - DAFF](#)

H5 bird flu mainly affects birds. Cats and dogs can sometimes get sick if they eat or interact with infected animals. To reduce the risk, keep pets away from sick or dead birds and other wildlife. Keep dogs on a leash, especially near wildlife, and cats contained. This also helps protect our wildlife from our pet cats and dogs. If you have pet birds or backyard chickens, there are simple steps you can take to help protect your birds.

Find out more: [Bird owners and bird flu - DAFF](#)

Australia has experienced outbreaks of an unrelated strain of bird flu previously, called H7. These outbreaks affected poultry and egg production but did not impact wildlife. We have contained and eradicated H7 bird flu in poultry many times over the past 50 years.

The current detections involve the more serious H5 strain that has been circulating globally.

The Australian Centre for Disease Control (CDC) regularly reassesses the risk of H5 bird flu to people in Australia. The current risk is low.

Bird flu rarely spreads to people as transmission usually requires close contact with infected birds, other infected animals or contaminated environments. Spread between people is also very rare.

Find out more about human health and H5 bird flu, including symptoms in people: [Bird flu \(avian influenza\) | Australian Centre for Disease Control](#)

Yes. Food Standards Australia New Zealand has advised bird flu is not a food safety risk for chicken meat and eggs if they are handled and cooked correctly. Practice good hand hygiene by washing your hands and utensils after handling animals, eggs or raw meat, and thoroughly cook meat and eggs before eating.

If you see sick or dead birds or other animals, do not touch them.

Avoid contact. Record what you see. Report multiple sick or dead birds or other animals to the Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888 from anywhere in Australia.

Reports to the EAD hotline are carefully assessed according to risk of H5 bird flu. This may lead to a site visit and sampling.

Not every report will result in bird collection or testing, and you may only be contacted if more information is required. Your report is still valuable, as it helps state and territory authorities monitor the situation and decide whether further investigation is needed.

While the human health risk of H5 bird flu remains low, we acknowledge that environmental concerns, including the health and welfare of our wildlife and domestic animals, can have effects on people's mental health and wellbeing.

Staying connected with your community and sticking to trusted sources of information helps keep things in perspective.

If you or someone you know is experiencing feelings that make it difficult to do everyday activities, the following services can help:

Medicare Mental Health provides free, confidential support Monday to Friday, 8:30 am to 5:00 pm (except public holidays). Call [1800 595 212](tel:1800595212) or visit [medicarementalhealth.gov.au](https://medicarementalhealth.gov.au). You don't need a Medicare card, referral or appointment to obtain support.

The following 24-7 support services are also available:

- [Beyond Blue](#): 1300 22 46 36
- [Kids Helpline](#): 1800 55 1800
- [13YARN](#) (13 92 76) - national crisis support for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples
- [Lifeline](#): 13 11 14 or [lifeline.org.au](https://lifeline.org.au).

If H5 bird flu spreads in animals in Australia, First Nations communities could be affected differently to other communities.

We acknowledge that the threat of H5 bird flu can be concerning for First Nations communities, as it may impact totems, culturally significant animals, and the health of Country.

If you're feeling worried, talk to someone you trust, like a health worker, ranger or community leader. Looking after each other and Country is something we can do together.

[13YARN](#) (13 92 76) is a culturally safe, free and confidential support service for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples. Community members who are feeling distressed, worried or overwhelmed are encouraged to call 13 92 76 at any time, day or night.

Resources to support education and information sharing are available at [Resources for bird flu](#).

## **Further information**

Visit [birdflu.gov.au](https://birdflu.gov.au) for the latest information, confirmed detections and advice on H5 bird flu.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/pests-diseases-weeds/animal/avian-influenza/faq>